

Ancient Maya

In around 2000 BCE, the eastern part of Central America and modern-day Mexico saw the rise of the Maya civilization, which grew to become one of the most advanced of its time. The ancient Maya constructed large cities in which they built tall pyramid temples. They also made beautiful works of art, and created a sophisticated writing system.

The Maya homeland contained a central rainforest, with dry regions to the north, and highlands to the south. They cleared areas of rainforest for farmland to grow crops, which could support grand cities with tens of thousands of people.



▲ ROYAL RITUALS

Maya kings and queens believed they were descended from gods, and offered their blood in rituals to contact and honor them. They often drew a thorn-studded rope across their tongue to draw blood. This stone carving shows a queen of Yaxchilan performing a bloodletting ceremony.

The nine terraces of the pyramid represent the nine levels of the Maya underworld.

The Maya were greatly influenced by other civilizations of the region, such as the Olmecs and the Zapotecs. From them they inherited a calendar system. Ancient Maya people were able to predict eclipses and the movements of the moon as well as the planet Venus, and used their understanding of the skies to create an accurate calendar.

After 800 CE many Maya cities had begun to decline or collapse. Some historians believe that this was due to constant warfare and decreasing natural resources.

▼ PYRAMID TEMPLE

The center of every Maya city was a ceremonial area, with tall pyramids that were topped with temples. These pyramids were sometimes tombs for kings who were worshipped in the temple. Below is the temple of King Pakal the Great of the city of Palenque.



Priests performed rituals at the temple on top of the pyramid.



▲ WRITING

The Maya created a complete writing system using symbols called glyphs to represent both words and syllables, and produced books with pages made of tree bark. The glyphs run along the top of the page shown above.